THE COMPLETE RULES

A Tavola!

One deck. Forty foods. Five Italian card games, easiest first.

THE DECK

Forty cards in four suits: **Formaggi** (Cheese), **Pasta**, **Forno** (Bakery) and **Carni** (Meats), each from 10 down to 1. Within a suit, a higher number always beats a lower one. Cards read both ways up, so hold them either way.



1. **Rank and suit.**
2. **Chef's hat:** points in Chef's Choice and Head Chef (10s to 6s only).
3. **Stars:** points in Crowd Pleasers.
4. **The dish:** Italian at the top, English at the bottom.

The 10s, 9s and 8s have their numbers in **10** gold, **9** silver and **8** copper: they are the declaration cards of Crowd Pleasers. In Hot Potato and Mop Up a card is simply worth its number.

Card	10	9	8	7	6	5	4 to 1	Deck
Hat points	11	10	4	3	2	0	0	**120**
Stars	1	1	3	1	1	1	0	**32**

WORDS YOU WILL MEET

Trick one card from each player in turn; the best card *wins* them all.
Lead play the first card of a trick.
Follow suit play the same suit as the card led.
Trump a suit that beats every other suit.
Stock the face-down pile you draw from.
Hand one deck, played out. A **game**: hands until someone wins.

PLAY TO THE RIGHT

As in Italy, everything goes counterclockwise: deal one card at a time, starting with the player on the dealer's right, who also plays first. After each game the deal passes to the right. Partners sit opposite each other.

WHICH GAME FIRST?

Game	Players	Level
Hot Potato *Patata Bollente*	2 to 30	● ○ ○ ○ Easy
Mop Up *Scarpetta*	2 to 4	● ● ○ ○ Moderate
Chef's Choice *Tanto di Cappello*, **Head Chef** *Capo Cuoco*	2 to 4, and 5	● ● ● ○ Intermediate
Crowd Pleasers *Tre Stelle*	2, or 4 in teams	● ● ● ● Advanced

Each game has a player aid, a card with its rules in brief: keep it on the table while you learn.

Hot Potato *Patata Bollente*

● ○ ○ ○ **Level 1 of 4 · Easy**

2 to 30 players · based on Passa la carta · the last player with points wins

Each round everyone is served one card, and the lowest loses a point. Don't like yours? Pass it down the table before the reveal.

SETTING THE TABLE

Everyone starts with **3 points**: keep count in your head, and say it out loud as you are dealt your card.

EACH ROUND

1. **Deal.** The dealer deals one card face down to each player, themselves included. Keep yours hidden.
2. **Keep or pass.** From the dealer's right, each player still in keeps their card or passes it. Passing is a swap: the next player still in *must* take your card and give you theirs, then keeps or passes the card they now hold.
3. **An 8 is safe.** Hold an 8? You may show it at any time: you keep it, and the player before you can't pass to you.
4. **The dealer goes last**, and can keep their card or swap it with the top card of the deck.
5. **Reveal.** Everyone turns their card face up. Among the players still in, the lowest number loses a point, and so does every card tied with it.

> **Example.** Five players reveal 9, 3, 6, 3 and 10. Both players holding a 3 lose a point.

OUT, AND BACK IN

At 0 points you are out: you no longer keep or pass, but you are still dealt a card each round, **face up**. If your card has the same number as a card that loses a point, you win a point back and you are in again.

THE NEXT ROUND

The dealer puts the round's cards face up under the deck and deals again. When there aren't enough face-down cards for everyone, the deal passes to the right and the new dealer shuffles all the cards. A dealer who goes out passes the deal on.

WINNING

The last player with points wins. If the last players all go out in the same round and nobody comes back in, they share the win.

TIPS

- Pass a 1, 2 or 3; keep a 7 or better.
- The more players, the safer a middling card: with ten a 5 is rarely the lowest; with three it often is.
- Notice which low cards have already gone under the deck this deal.
- As dealer, swapping with the deck is a blind gamble: only take it with a really low card.

House rules. Deal two cards each, keep or pass one or both, and lose a point for each of the lowest. Or let a player who is out take one of your points to come back in.

Mop Up *Scarpetta*

● ● ○ ○ **Level 2 of 4 · Moderate**

2 or 3 players, or 4 in teams · based on Scopa · first to 11 points

Capture cards from the middle of the table, the ***plate****, by matching or adding up numbers. Wipe the plate clean for a bonus point: fare la scarpetta is mopping your plate with bread.*

SETTING THE TABLE

Cards are worth their number; hats and stars play no part. Deal **3 cards** each, then turn **4** face up in the middle: the plate. If three or four 10s land on it, deal again.

YOUR TURN

From the dealer's right, play one card face up on your turn:

- **Match:** if a card on the plate has the same number, take it.
- **Add up:** if two or more cards on the plate add up to your card's number, take them all.
- If you can take, you must. If your card matches a single card, you must take that one rather than a group. With more than one way to take, you choose.
- If you can't take anything, your card stays on the plate.

Keep what you take, with the card you played, face down in your pile.

> **Example.** The plate holds 2, 3, 5 and 7. Play a 5 and you must take the 5, not the 2 and 3. Play a 9 and you take the 2 and 7. Play a 10 and you choose: the 3 and 7, or the 2, 3 and 5.

SCARPETTA!

If your capture leaves the plate empty, that is a **Scarpetta**, worth a point. Put the card you played face up and crosswise in your pile to keep count. The next player simply plays a card onto the empty plate.

> **Example.** The plate holds a 4 and a 6. You play a 10, take both, and the plate is clean: Scarpetta!

THE REST OF THE HAND

When everyone's three cards are played, deal 3 more each; nothing more goes on the plate. The dealer always plays last. When the deck is used up and every card played, whoever made the last capture takes what is left on the plate. The very last play of the deck can't score a Scarpetta.

SCORING: ONE POINT EACH

Scarpetta	each time you wiped the plate clean
All You Can Eat	the most cards
Panetteria	the most Forno cards
Pizza	the **8** of Forno
Dream Menu	the most 8s; if tied, the fewest 1s, then 2s, 3s, 4s

A tie scores nothing; with three players you need strictly more than each of the others. Keep a running total: the first to **11** wins. If several reach 11 in the same hand, the highest wins; if they are level, play another hand. Four players: partners sit opposite and share one pile.

TIPS

- After you play, add up what is left on the plate: if it comes to 10 or less, the next player may sweep it all. Try to leave more than 10.
- When you have a choice, take Forno cards and 8s: they win Panetteria and the Dream Menu, and the 8 of Forno is a point by itself.
- There are four of each number: count the 8s and the Forno cards as they go.

Chef's Choice *Tanto di Cappello*

●●●○ **Level 3 of 4 · Intermediate**

2, 3 or 4 players · based on Briscola · the most hat points wins

Win tricks that hold the cards with the biggest chef's hats. One suit, the ***trump****, beats all the others: it is the chef's choice of the day.*

SETTING THE TABLE

Deal **3 cards** each. Turn the next card face up, half under the deck: its suit is the trump for the whole hand, and it is the last card drawn. The rest is the stock.

PLAYING A TRICK

The player on the dealer's right leads; each other player plays one card in turn. You **never** have to follow suit.

- The highest **trump** wins the trick.
- If no trump was played, the highest card of the **suit led** wins.
- A card of any other suit can't win, however high.

Example. 🍝 Pasta is trump. Anna leads the 7 of Formaggi, Ben plays the 10 of Carni, Carla the 2 of Pasta. Carla wins: hers is the only trump. Had she played a Forno card, Anna's 7 would win: Ben's 10 is not the suit led.

AFTER EACH TRICK

The winner takes the cards face down, then everyone draws one card, the winner first, and the winner leads next. When the stock is gone, play out your hand.

SCORING

Add up the hats in your tricks (table on page 1): 120 in the deck, so 61 wins; 60 each is a draw. Play one game, or the best of three.

Three players: take out one "1" first; everyone plays alone and the highest total wins. **Four players:** partners sit opposite and score together; agree first whether secret signals are allowed.

TIPS

- Don't spend a trump on a trick with no hats in it: save trumps to win the 10s and 9s, worth 11 and 10.
- With nothing better, lead a low card (5 to 1) of a plain suit: it gives nothing away.
- Playing last in a trick is an advantage: you see every card before you choose.
- Count the trumps: there are ten. Know when the 10 and 9 have gone.
- In teams, add a big card to a trick your partner is already winning.

Head Chef *Capo Cuoco*

●●●○ **Level 3 of 4 · Intermediate**

5 players · based on Briscola Chiamata · the most points over an agreed number of games

Chef's Choice for five, with an auction. Bid to run the kitchen, choose the trump, and hire a ***secret sous chef*** *by calling a card. The other three are the* ***diners****.*

BIDDING

Deal **8 cards** each, the whole deck; nothing is turned up. From the dealer's right, going round, bid or pass. A bid is the hat points you think your kitchen will make, **61 to 120**, and must beat the last bid. Once you pass, you are out of the bidding. When everyone else has passed, the highest bidder is the **head chef**. If all five pass, deal again.

THE CALL

The head chef names the trump suit and calls one card of it, such as "Pasta, the 9". Its holder is the secret **sous chef** and keeps quiet until that card is played. Head chef and sous chef are the **kitchen**; the other three are the **diners**, playing together. Call a card from your own hand and you cook alone against four.

The markers. Turn the trump suit card so the chosen suit is at the top, lay the value card across its lower half with the called value's row at the top, and slide it until the Called card arrow points at the value.

PLAYING AND SCORING

The dealer's right leads. Play all eight tricks as in Chef's Choice, with no stock. The kitchen adds up both players' hats and needs at least its bid.

	Head chef	Sous chef	Each diner
Kitchen achieves the bid	1	1	**0**
Chef alone achieves it	2	–	**0**
Kitchen fails the bid	0	0	**1**

Keep a running total over an agreed number of games; ten make a good evening. The most points wins.

TIPS

- Bid on a long suit: four or five cards of one suit, with its 10 or 9, make a good trump.
- Call the best trump you don't hold, usually the 10 or the 9: your sous chef will be strong.
- Sous chef: drop your hats onto tricks the head chef is winning; staying hidden may tempt the diners to feed you points.
- Diners: watch who helps the head chef. That is probably the sous chef.

Crowd Pleasers *Tre Stelle*

●●●● **Level 4 of 4 · Advanced**

2 players, or 4 in two teams · based on Tresette · first to 69 points

No trumps, and you must follow suit. Win the tricks with the most ***stars****, the public vote. The 8s carry three stars each, but the 10 and 9 of their suit beat them.*

SETTING THE TABLE

Partners sit opposite. Deal **10 cards** each, the whole deck. If you have fewer than 3 stars in your hand, you may call for a re-deal.

DECLARATIONS

Before the first trick, declare these out loud for bonus points, using the gold, silver and copper cards (**10**, **9**, **8**). They go to your team whoever wins the tricks.

Feast	the 10, 9 and 8 of one suit	**9**
Tasting Platter	three 10s, three 9s or three 8s	**9**
Large Tasting Platter	all four 10s, 9s or 8s	**12**

Count cards, not stars. You can score several declarations, and a card can count in more than one (a Feast's 10 can also be in a Tasting Platter), but four of a kind replaces three of the same rank: four 10s score 12, not 21. At your second trick, say the suit of your Feast, or the suit missing from your Tasting Platter. The other team may check at the end of the hand.

PLAYING

The dealer's right leads. You must **follow suit** if you can; if you can't, play any card (it can't win). The highest card of the suit led wins, and leads next.

Example. Anna leads the 7 of Formaggi. Ben follows with the 9 of Formaggi; Carla has no Formaggi left and throws the 10 of Carni; Dino must follow and plays the 8 of Formaggi. Ben's 9 wins, and with it 1 + 1 + 1 + 3 = 6 stars.

Table talk. Only the leader may speak, about the card just led: **NomNom** (*Gnam*): win this and lead the suit back to me. **Bleugh** (*Che schifo*): I have more of this suit, but nothing good. **Finished** (*Finito*): my last of this suit. Or play in silence: agree first.

SCORING

Each star is **1 point**, and the last trick **3 more**: 35 a hand, plus declarations. First team to **69** wins. Claim the win at any time, even after declaring; if you are short, you lose. If both teams pass 69 in one hand, the higher wins; if tied, play on.

Two players. Deal 10 each; the rest is the stock. After each trick the winner draws a card and shows it, then the other player. When the stock is gone, play out the last ten. Same declarations and scoring.

TIPS

- Don't lead an 8 while the 10 or 9 of its suit is still out: you will likely hand over three stars.
- Count the 10s and 9s: once both have gone, that suit's 8 is the top card.
- Run out of a suit early: then you can throw away starless cards (4 to 1) when it is led.
- Keep a high card for the end: the last trick is worth 3.
- Declarations are free points: always check your hand before the first trick.

Your first evening

Start with **Hot Potato** to get to know the cards, then try **Mop Up** with two or three players. Once tricks and trumps feel natural in **Chef's Choice**, bring five friends to **Head Chef**, and keep **Crowd Pleasers** for when you are ready to count stars and talk to your partner.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Chef's Choice: can a high card of another suit win? No. Only a trump, or the suit that was led, can win a trick.

Crowd Pleasers: and here? Only the suit led: there are no trumps, so a card of another suit never wins.

Mop Up: does my Scarpetta card still count? Yes. It is turned crosswise only to keep count; it stays in your pile for All You Can Eat and the rest.

Hot Potato: what if the next player is out? Passing always goes to the next player still in.